California neuroscience researcher directory

Checked 13 October 2026. The core list has 19 researchers: 17 publicly recognized in the Hispanic/Latinx Atlas and two included using explicitly documented Latin American national-origin biographies. The latter are labeled and are not claims of personal self-identification. Two related-field lab leaders and one Spain-origin PI appear separately. Nineteen unresolved leads are not classified as confirmed Latino PIs. This is a source-backed, broad search result, not a complete statewide census.

Activity evidence A = an accessible lab, team or institutional page explicitly describes the independent group; B = converging current faculty/group and research evidence, with lab page blocked. These grades describe evidence quality, not scientific merit. No hiring availability is inferred. Less direct activity evidence is retained in the follow-up section outside the active count.

Background evidence is independent of activity evidence. No surnames, photos, language ability or participant populations were used to assign identity.

Core neuroscience

Walter G. Gonzalez — University of California, San Francisco

Region: Bay Area.

Research: Learned song, motor behavior, interregional communication and neural population dynamics. Closest verified song/vocal-behavior match.

Models and methods: Zebra finches and mice; imaging, electrophysiology and circuit manipulation.

Lab/profile: https://www.chembiophys.com/

Activity evidence (A): Team page explicitly identifies the PI, lab establishment in 2023, and current trainees, including a postdoc joining in 2025.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Selected research: https://doi.org/10.1126/science.aav9199

Markita del Carpio Landry — University of California, Berkeley

Region: Bay Area.

Research: Neurochemical imaging and nanosensors for measuring signaling during behavior. Strong technology and behavioral-neuroscience fit.

Models and methods: Chemical sensor development; dopamine imaging, including research in voles.

Lab/profile: https://landrylab.com/

Activity evidence (B): Current Berkeley faculty page names the Landry lab; recent indexed work includes dopamine dynamics and social behavior. Lab homepage blocked, institutional profile checked.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Selected research: https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2509561123

Mercedes Paredes — University of California, San Francisco

Region: Bay Area.

Research: Human interneuron development, neuronal migration and neurogenesis.

Models and methods: Human developmental tissue and cellular/neurodevelopmental approaches.

Lab/profile: https://paredeslab.ucsf.edu/

Activity evidence (B): Current UCSF profile lists Professor of Neurology and research activity; independent Paredes lab is named in the Atlas. Lab homepage blocked; profile checked.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Arturo Álvarez-Buylla — University of California, San Francisco

Region: Bay Area.

Research: Neural stem cells, adult neurogenesis and mechanisms of brain development and repair.

Models and methods: Cellular and developmental neuroscience.

Lab/profile: https://profiles.ucsf.edu/arturo.alvarez-buylla

Activity evidence (B): Current UCSF faculty/research profile and recent indexed research support continuing independent research.

Background evidence: Public biography explicitly describes Mexican origin and birth in Mexico City. National-origin evidence, not a claim about preferred personal ethnic identification. Source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Arturo_Alvarez-Buylla

Elva Diaz — University of California, Davis

Region: Sacramento/Davis.

Research: Neural proliferation, synapse formation and plasticity.

Models and methods: Rodent systems; functional genomics and cellular neuroscience.

Lab/profile: https://biology.ucdavis.edu/people/elva-diaz

Activity evidence (A): Current institutional profile explicitly describes her laboratory and neural-development research.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Santiago Ramírez — University of California, Davis

Region: Sacramento/Davis.

Research: Orchid-bee sensory evolution, brain organization, sociality and mating signals. Strong comparative neuroethology fit.

Models and methods: Orchid bees; comparative neuroanatomy, behavior and evolutionary biology.

Lab/profile: https://www.sanramlab.org/

Activity evidence (B): Current UC Davis faculty profile lists Professor and lab link; 2025 and 2026 primary papers address bee neuroanatomy and neuroplasticity. Lab site blocked; institutional profile checked.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Selected research: https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-025-92712-3

Rebecca Calisi-Rodríguez — University of California, Davis

Region: Sacramento/Davis.

Research: Animal behavior, stress physiology and behavioral neuroendocrinology; current Green Care work adds animal–human and nature-related health questions.

Models and methods: Animal behavior, physiological measures and community-facing research.

Lab/profile: https://greencarelab.ucdavis.edu/

Activity evidence (A): Current Green Care lab site identifies her leadership, research, team and opportunities.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Constanza J. Cortes — University of Southern California

Region: Greater Los Angeles.

Research: Exercise, muscle–brain signaling, geroprotection and neurodegeneration.

Models and methods: Mouse models, exercise biology and aging-related molecular analyses.

Lab/profile: https://gero.usc.edu/labs/corteslab/

Activity evidence (A): Current USC team page explicitly identifies PI and current graduate, undergraduate and research staff members.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Valerie A. Tornini — University of California, Los Angeles

Region: Greater Los Angeles.

Research: Neural development, micropeptides, gene regulation and evolution of neural cell types.

Models and methods: Zebrafish and sea lamprey; genetics, developmental and behavioral approaches.

Lab/profile: https://www.torninilab.org/

Activity evidence (A): Current lab/team pages identify PI and research program.

Background evidence: Atlas recognition; her own lab biography also states that her parents moved from Uruguay to the U.S. before her birth. Source: https://www.torninilab.org/team

Selected research: https://doi.org/10.7554/eLife.82249

Michael F. Wells — University of California, Los Angeles

Region: Greater Los Angeles.

Research: Human neural-cell models, neurodevelopment, genetic variation and environmental effects.

Models and methods: Human stem-cell-derived neural cells and pooled cell-model experiments.

Lab/profile: https://www.mfwellslab.com/

Activity evidence (A): Current independent lab site names the UCLA group and ongoing research. A coauthored cichlid review is not treated as proof that this lab performs fish experiments.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Leanna M. Hernandez — University of California, Los Angeles

Region: Greater Los Angeles.

Research: Neurodevelopment, autism, psychiatric genetics and neuroimaging.

Models and methods: Human neuroimaging and genetic approaches.

Lab/profile: https://www.hernandezlabucla.org/

Activity evidence (A): Current lab homepage and Atlas identify independent UCLA research group.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Mirella Díaz-Santos — University of California, Los Angeles

Region: Greater Los Angeles.

Research: Cognitive aging and Alzheimer disease; prevention, detection and management in Latine/Hispanic communities.

Models and methods: Human cognitive and clinical research.

Lab/profile: https://eastonad.ucla.edu/research/research-labs/equity-for-latinx/hispanic-healthy-aging-elha-lab

Activity evidence (A): Current UCLA Easton Center page explicitly identifies her as director of the ELHA lab.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Adys Mendizabal — University of California, Los Angeles

Region: Greater Los Angeles.

Research: Access to neurological care and clinical research, particularly Huntington disease. Clinical/health-services neuroscience fit.

Models and methods: Electronic health records and interviews with patients and providers.

Lab/profile: https://www.uclahealth.org/providers/adys-mendizabal

Activity evidence (A): Current UCLA profile explicitly describes her lab and its research program.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Arturo Zavala — California State University, Long Beach

Region: Greater Los Angeles.

Research: Developmental psychopharmacology, addiction, serotonin and effects of drug exposure.

Models and methods: Animal behavioral models, neurochemical, molecular and pharmacological approaches.

Lab/profile: https://cws.csulb.edu/mentor/mentor/90

Activity evidence (A): Current CSULB research-mentor page explicitly describes his behavioral neuroscience laboratory and research programs.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Martin Riccomagno — University of California, Riverside

Region: Inland Empire.

Research: Axon guidance, circuit assembly and pruning; neuron–glia interactions.

Models and methods: Developmental neuroscience, mouse systems and molecular/genetic tools.

Lab/profile: https://www.riccomagnolab.org/

Activity evidence (A): Lab site identifies UCR group, projects, team and recent publications.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Stacey Glasgow — University of California, San Diego

Region: San Diego.

Research: Glial development, spinal motor neurons and nervous-system disease.

Models and methods: Cellular/developmental neuroscience and disease models.

Lab/profile: https://www.theglasgowlab.com/

Activity evidence (A): Current independent lab site identifies group and research; primary research includes spinal motor-neuron development.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Selected research: https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.adu3346

Andrew S. Mendiola — University of California, San Diego

Region: San Diego.

Research: Neuroinflammation, epigenetics and metabolic regulation.

Models and methods: Molecular and cellular approaches to neuroimmune mechanisms.

Lab/profile: https://profiles.ucsd.edu/andrew.mendiola

Activity evidence (B): Current UCSD faculty profile identifies lab website and research; independent group listed in 2026 Atlas. Lab homepage blocked.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Alex Chaim — University of California, San Diego

Region: San Diego.

Research: DNA/RNA damage and its roles in neurodegeneration and cancer. Neurodegeneration is one branch of a broader molecular research program.

Models and methods: Molecular and cellular biology.

Lab/profile: https://chaimlab.com/

Activity evidence (A): Current lab homepage identifies UCSD group, team, research, publications and recruitment information.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Alysson R. Muotri — University of California, San Diego

Region: San Diego.

Research: Neural stem-cell models, brain organoids, neurodevelopment and evolution of cognition.

Models and methods: Human stem cells and brain organoids.

Lab/profile: https://pediatrics.ucsd.edu/research/faculty-labs/muotri-lab/index.html

Activity evidence (A): Current UCSD institutional lab page and faculty profile explicitly identify research group; current indexed research supports ongoing activity.

Background evidence: Public biography explicitly describes him as a Brazilian geneticist/developmental biologist. National-origin evidence; not a claim of personal Hispanic self-identification. Source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Alysson_Muotri

Related research, separate from core neuroscience count

Jocelyn Meza — University of California, Los Angeles

Region: Greater Los Angeles.

Research: Mental-health equity, suicide prevention and access to treatment. Related clinical/behavioral research; not labeled a neural-circuit lab.

Models and methods: Human mental-health and intervention research.

Lab/profile: https://heart.semel.ucla.edu/

Activity evidence (A): Current HEART lab site and Atlas explicitly identify founder and PI.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Natalia Caporale — University of California, Davis

Region: Sacramento/Davis.

Research: STEM/neuroscience education, institutional barriers and evidence-based interventions. Neuroscience education rather than experimental nervous-system research.

Models and methods: Education research and teaching assessment.

Lab/profile: https://equitablestem.org/

Activity evidence (A): Current Equity in STEM Education research-group site names Caporale lab and active research.

Background evidence: Publicly featured in the Fred Hutch Atlas of Inspiring Hispanic/Latinx Scientists; specific nationality not inferred. Source: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

Documented Spain-origin, separate

Carlos Portera-Cailliau — University of California, Los Angeles

Region: Greater Los Angeles.

Research: Sensory cortical circuits, social touch, autism and fragile X-related mechanisms.

Models and methods: Mouse cortical imaging, circuit physiology and behavior.

Lab/profile: https://porteralab.dgsom.ucla.edu/people/carlos-portera-cailliau-mdphd

Activity evidence (A): Current lab PI biography explicitly identifies independent NIH-funded UCLA lab.

Background evidence: Own institutional PI biography states born and raised in Madrid, Spain. Spanish/Hispanic-origin entry, kept separate from Latino/Latin American-origin count. Source: https://porteralab.dgsom.ucla.edu/people/carlos-portera-cailliau-mdphd

Selected research: https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-025-59852-6

Unresolved leads and exclusions: outside the confirmed count

These are scientific follow-up leads, not confirmation of both Latino/Hispanic background and current independent lab leadership. Some have documented background but unresolved activity. Inclusion never implies background from a surname.

- **Diana Bautista (UC Berkeley)**: Touch, itch, pain and sensory neuroimmune mechanisms. Active sensory research verified; Latino/Hispanic background not established by examined sources. Link: https://mcb.berkeley.edu/faculty/neurobiology/bautistad

- **Andrea Gomez (UC Berkeley)**: Synaptic organization, plasticity and psychedelic mechanisms. Active lab verified. Institutional story about Indigenous knowledge does not establish her ethnicity. Link: https://mcb.berkeley.edu/faculty/neurobiology/gomeza

- **José M. Carmena (UC Berkeley)**: Brain–machine interfaces and motor learning. Scientifically relevant lead. Fellowship page blocked; background and current independent group need clearer source verification. Link: https://www.gf.org/fellows/jose-m-carmena/

- **Luis de Lecea (Stanford)**: Sleep/arousal circuits and neuromodulation. Active Stanford lab verified. Spanish university training alone was not treated as Spanish or Latino identity evidence. Link: https://med.stanford.edu/delecea.html

- **Carlos Lois (Caltech)**: Song learning, neural circuits and neuronal integration. Explicit active PI page verified. Valencia medical degree does not establish Spanish or Latino identity. Link: https://www.theloislab.com/people

- **Antonio Rangel (Caltech)**: Value-based decision-making and neuroeconomics. Active PI verified. Background unverified; Wikipedia namesakes are a badminton player and footballer, not this scientist. Link:

https://www.rnl.caltech.edu/people

- **Hector M. González (UC San Diego)**: Latino cognitive aging and population neuroscience. Independent SOL-INCA leadership verified. Studying Latino participants does not establish personal background. Link: https://profiles.ucsd.edu/hector.m.gonzalez

- **Adriana Galván (UCLA)**: Adolescent brain development and decision-making. Active lab verified; examined sources did not establish Latino/Hispanic identity. Link: https://galvanlab.psych.ucla.edu/

- **Santiago Morales (USC)**: Developmental emotion regulation, EEG and fMRI. Current faculty and research verified; background and separate current lab-team page not fully established. Link: https://dornsife.usc.edu/profile/santiago-morales/

- **Miguel Eckstein (UC Santa Barbara)**: Visual perception and attention. Current faculty profile verified; Latino/Hispanic background not established. Link: https://psych.ucsb.edu/people/faculty/miguel-eckstein

- **Sergio Baranzini (UCSF)**: Multiple sclerosis, neurogenetics and systems biology. Current research verified; Argentina degrees alone are not personal national-origin or ethnicity evidence. Link: https://profiles.ucsf.edu/sergio.baranzini

- **Gabriel Silva (UC San Diego)**: Bioengineering and computational/neural systems. Current faculty/research verified; background not established. Link: https://profiles.ucsd.edu/gabriel.silva

- **Miriam Hernández-Morales (UC Berkeley)**: Neuromodulation, neural circuits and glia. Atlas background evidence present; Assistant Scientist appointment alone did not verify an independent active lab. Personal page blocked. Link: https://miriamhmorales.com/

- **Brenda Bloodgood (UC San Diego)**: Neural plasticity and circuit physiology. Research-fit lead; personal Latino/Hispanic background not verified. This URL was not successfully checked in this review. Link: https://biology.ucsd.edu/research/faculty/bloodgood

- **Carolina Abdala (USC)**: Hearing and otoacoustic emissions. Strong auditory lead from previous research; demographic evidence and current independent lab verification unresolved. Link: https://sites.usc.edu/abdalab/

- **Fernando Gomez-Pinilla (UCLA)**: Exercise, nutrition and neural plasticity. Research-fit lead; examined guessed personal URLs failed, so no verified lab link or demographic classification supplied. Link: https://www.ucla.edu/

- **Roberto Malinow (UC San Diego)**: Synaptic plasticity and learning. Public biography describes Buenos Aires birth; current official profile says emeritus. Independent active lab status not established, so excluded from active count. Link: https://profiles.ucsd.edu/roberto.malinow

- **Keith Trujillo (CSU San Marcos)**: Psychopharmacology and behavioral neuroscience. Atlas establishes public background association but lists emeritus; current independent active lab not verified. Link: https://www.fredhutch.org/en/about/about-the-hutch/faculty-development/atlas-of-inspiring-hispanic-latinx-scientists.html

- **Carlos Villalba-Galea (University of the Pacific, Stockton)**: Voltage sensing, potassium channels and mechanisms of electrical excitability.. Atlas background evidence is present and recent research is indexed, but a directly verified current independent lab was not established. Excluded from active count; 2024 paper: https://doi.org/10.1085/jgp.202213284 Link: https://www.pacific.edu/campus-directory/carlos-villalba-galea

Scope exclusions

Pablo Lara-Gonzalez and Jorge Torres appear in the Hispanic/Latinx Atlas and lead cell-biology research, but the examined descriptions did not establish a neuroscience research program. Eva Nogales has distinguished structural-biology research and a Spanish background, but was not counted as a core neuroscience PI merely because structural biology can inform neural research. Laura Melissa Guzman and Alejandra Echeverri Ochoa were not counted as neuroscience PIs from animal/ecological interests alone. No ethnicity claim is added for other excluded leads.

Coverage and remaining gaps

The search examined California candidates across the Bay Area, Davis/Sacramento, the Central Valley, greater Los Angeles, the Inland Empire and San Diego. It used the statewide subset of the Atlas, institutional pages, direct web searches and primary-paper records. Stanford, Caltech, UC Santa Barbara, UC Irvine, UC Santa Cruz, Salk and Scripps remain areas for further verification; a missing confirmed entry is not proof that the institution has no Latino neuroscience PIs. Search-engine rate limits and blocked profile pages limited some follow-up searches.